

Contextual Overview: Kenya's Education System Transition

Introduction

This document provides relevant context on Kenya's transition from the 8-4-4 system to the Competency-Based Education (CBE) system. As the pioneer cohort entered Senior Secondary School (Grade 10) in January 2026, understanding the rationale, history, and implementation of this transition is important for all education stakeholders.

Background and rationale for the transition

For nearly four decades, Kenya has used the 8-4-4 education system, which was introduced in 1985. The 8-4-4 system consists of 8 years of primary education, 4 years of secondary education, and a minimum of 4 years of university education. While the 8-4-4 system was initially conceived to foster self-reliance, technical expertise, and vocational training, its implementation over the years faced significant criticism—primarily centred on the system being too academic and heavily dependent on summative, high-stakes exams, failing to adequately prepare youth for employment, and thus leading to high levels of unemployment. (Chacha, Gabon a175)

The need for reform culminated in the conceptualization of the Competency-Based Curriculum (CBC)—subsequently refined and expanded into the broader framework of Competency-Based Education (CBE). The transition was formally initiated following comprehensive national inquiries, such as a summative evaluation of the 8-4-4 system, and a comprehensive national needs assessment study conducted by the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD). These investigations established that the 8-4-4 structure was failing to develop critical skills and values needed. (Munavu, 1)

Primary drivers for the transition (Chacha, Gabon a174; a183-a184)

1. **More holistic development:** Moving away from dense content across multiple subjects—which required long hours of study, and instead creating pathways to cultivate non-academic capabilities, and allow for more holistic development.
2. **Reduction of exam pressure:** Eliminating high-stakes exams like KCPE and KCSE, which favoured memorization-style learning, rather than building problem-solving and critical thinking skills.
3. **Skill-based learning:** Moving away from acquisition of knowledge and exam-oriented results toward deep skill mastery and vocational training.
4. **Socio-economic alignment:** Synchronizing national education with the industrial, technological, and vocational needs of the job market, and the Kenya Vision 2030 agenda.

Structural and pedagogical differences

The shift from 8-4-4 to CBE fundamentally changes the structural organization of basic education, the delivery and assessment models within classrooms, and the level of learning specialization.

A. Structural organization changes

While the 8-4-4 system separated basic education into two distinct tiers (Primary and Secondary) before tertiary education, the CBE system changed the structure into a 2-6-3-3-3 model:

- 2 years of pre-primary education (PP1 and PP2)
- 6 years of primary education- divided into lower and upper primary (Grades 1-6)
- 3 years of junior secondary school (Grades 7, 8, and 9)
- 3 years of senior secondary school (Grades 10, 11, and 12), and
- A minimum of 3 years of higher/tertiary education (Chacha, Gabon a174; a185)

B. Delivery models within classrooms

Unlike the objective-based 8-4-4 curriculum which focused on what knowledge learners could acquire, CBE prioritizes seven core competencies that emphasize what a student can do as a result of instruction.

The seven core competencies to be achieved by learners undergoing the CBE curriculum are:

1. Communication and collaboration
2. Self-efficacy
3. Critical thinking and problem-solving
4. Creativity and imagination
5. Citizenship
6. Digital literacy
7. Learning to learn (KICD 21)

The Competency-Based Education (CBE) system aims to improve learning outcomes through these strengths of a competency based curriculum:

1. **Learner-focused:** Education should prioritize the student's needs; the curriculum is designed to be flexible, allowing teachers to act as facilitators who tailor learning experiences to support diverse student backgrounds.
2. **Focus on competencies:** The priority is the practical application of knowledge rather than mere content memorization. While traditional subjects remain, they serve as a framework for developing core skills like literacy and numeracy over time.
3. **Opportunities for local decision-making and greater depth of study:** To avoid the constraints of prescriptive programming, the system grants teachers more freedom to adapt the curriculum to their specific classroom environment and student needs.
4. **Balance between formative and summative assessment:** The system reduces the reliance on high-stakes exams. Instead, it adopts a balanced approach that uses ongoing (formative) assessments to track continuous growth in literacy, numeracy, and cross-curricular skills.

5. **Digitally based:** Utilizing collaborative digital platforms allows for continuous curriculum updates and supports personalized learning, enabling students to progress at their own pace in various environments.
6. **Collaborative and co-development models:** Curriculum design is a shared process. By involving partners and local stakeholders in the creation of content, the system ensures that delivery remains flexible, exploratory, and relevant to the community.
7. **Synchronous development:** Moving away from sequential planning, the system integrates the development of study programs, assessments, and teaching resources. This unified approach encourages interdisciplinary learning and ensures all components of the curriculum work together seamlessly. (KICD 26-27)

C. Specialization pathways, and changes to school categorizations

A key change with the CBE system is the introduction of specialized academic and vocational training at the senior secondary school level (Grades 10–12). Rather than putting all pupils through a homogenous curriculum, learners choose from three primary pathways based on performance, psychometric interest profiling, and localized capabilities:

1. Science, Technology, Engineering, and Mathematics (STEM), expected to be taken up by 60% of learners
2. Social Sciences / Humanities, expected to be taken up by 25% of learners
3. Arts and Sports Science, expected to be taken up by 15% of learners. (KICD 51, 145)

Note: the expected distribution of student uptake is based on what is expected would enable Kenya to meet the human capital requirements for Vision 2030– Kenya’s agenda for national development. (KICD 141)

The classification of senior secondary schools has also undergone a change, with the classification used in the 8-4-4 system (national, extra-county, county, and sub-county) being replaced by a four-cluster system: C1, C2, C3, and C4.

- **C1** (formerly national schools)
- **C2** (formerly extra-county schools)
- **C3** (formerly county schools)
- **C4** (formerly sub-county schools)

Beyond the cluster system, schools are further categorized by:

- **Pathways:** Triple pathway schools (offering all 3 pathways), or dual pathway schools (offering STEM- *required for all schools*- and only 1 other pathway)
- **Gender:** Single-gender or mixed-gender schools.
- **Accommodation:** Day or hybrid (day and boarding) schools.
- **Special needs and vocational:** Dedicated schools for learners with hearing, visual, or physical impairments, as well as vocational schools for those following the stage-based education pathway. (Ochieng, Education News)

The table below summarises the key differences highlighted above between the two systems:

Component	Former 8-4-4 system	Current CBE system
Basic structure	8-4-4: • 8 years primary school • 4 years secondary school • 4 years higher/tertiary education	2-6-3-3-3: • 2 years of pre-primary education (PP1 and PP2) • 6 years of primary education (Grades 1-6) • 3 years of junior secondary school (Grades 7, 8, and 9) • 3 years of senior secondary school (Grades 10, 11, and 12), • Minimum of 3 years of higher/tertiary education
Core philosophy / approach	Content-driven & teacher-centered: Focuses on memorization, theoretical knowledge accumulation, and academic qualifications.	Learner-centered & skill-based: Focuses on the practical application of knowledge, nurturing unique student talents, and developing job market-relevant competencies.
School categorization	Based on institutional prestige/tiers: • National schools • Extra-county schools • County schools • Sub-county schools	Based on multiple criteria: • Re-naming of previous classification • Pathways offered • Gender (single-gender or mixed) • Accommodation (day or hybrid) - Special needs and vocational
Subject coverage	Rigid, broad syllabus: All students take a fixed set of standardized academic subjects until secondary school graduation. Late specialization.	Early specialization; flexible learning: Broad foundations in primary/JSS. Early specialization in SSS across 3 pathways (STEM, Social Sciences, or Arts & Sports Science).

Primary assessment method	Summative evaluation: High-stakes, single national exams (KCPE and KCSE) that ranked students numerically and determined future placement.	Formative & continuous evaluation: Combination of school-based assessments and national assessments focused on skill mastery rather than ranking.
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Key timeline and milestones related to the transition

- **2017: The pilot phase & launch**
 - The Ministry of Education and the Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD) officially launched the CBC pilot phase in January 2017. The historic "pioneer cohort" entered the system at the Grade 1 level.
- **2019: National roll-out**
 - Full national implementation of the curriculum begins, officially replacing the 8-4-4 system step-by-step from pre-primary 1 (PP1) up to Grade 3.
- **2022: The first primary exit exam**
 - The pioneer cohort reached Grade 6 and sat for the inaugural Kenya Primary School Education Assessment (KPSEA).
- **2023: The start of junior secondary**
 - The Grade 6 graduates transitioned into Grade 7, marking the official launch of Junior Secondary School (JSS) across the country.
 - The final cohort of the previous 8-4-4 system completed primary school, and sat for the last KCPE exam, marking the end of 8-4-4 primary school studies.
- **2025: The first junior secondary school exit exam**
 - The pioneer cohort reached Grade 9, and over 1.1 million students sat for the first-ever Kenya Junior School Education Assessment (KJSEA).
- **2026: The launch of specialized secondary school**
 - Right now, in 2026, the pioneer cohort has officially entered Grade 10 (Senior Secondary School). For the first time in Kenya's history, students are no longer taking a blanket curriculum; instead, they have separated into three distinct pathways: STEM, Social Sciences, or Arts & Sports Science.
- **2027 (upcoming): The end of 8-4-4 learning**
 - The final 8-4-4 cohort will complete their high school education and sit for the KCSE exam, marking the end of all 8-4-4 learning
- **2028 (upcoming): First CBE cohort to complete basic education**
 - The inaugural CBE cohort will sit for the first Kenya Certificate of Basic Education (KCBE), and complete their basic education learning

References

1. Chacha, Valentine Rhobi; Gabon, Yasin Kuso. "The Education Transformation: A Comparative Study of Kenya's 8-4-4 System and the Competency-Based Curriculum." *TIJER – International Research Journal* ISSN 2349-9249, January 2026 Volume 13, Issue 1. www.tijer.org.
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3. Kenya Institute of Curriculum Development (KICD). "Basic Education Curriculum Framework", 2017.
4. Ochieng, Victor. "Categorisation of Senior Schools in New Education Dispensation." *Education News*, 11 Aug. 2025, <https://educationnews.co.ke/categorisation-of-senior-schools-in-new-education-dispensation/>.